drama's plot twist coming in a minute."

AI, of course, has a significant role to play in this rigmarole. AI-powered entertainment company DashVerse recently released *Raftaar*, a racing drama made entirely with generative AI, and is planning more sport, myth and sci-fi dramas using the technology, all genres which would have been far more expensive if shot in live-action. Hansraj, too, recently launched crime drama *Kaal Nagri*, with visuals made with AI, and voice acting by humans. "AI opens up a realm of possibilities in world-building," says Lalith Gudipati, co-founder of DashVerse. "We want more people to create stories that have never been created."

Shock and Awe

The inherent need for micro dramas to have shock value, melodrama and rushed character arcs means that there is no shortage of critics. The format naturally invites judgement that its audience base is not looking for high-quality storytelling. Naysayers may call the content catalogues on these apps 'cringe' and 'cheesy' but, honestly, that doesn't seem to matter much if you look at the comments below many of these shows: "terrible, but I can't stop watching it" is how one viewer describes *The Double Life of My Billionaire Husband*, a popular American micro drama on ReelShort.

Studios, too, have shed all qualms. While the industry has so far been spearheaded by independent studios, bigger fish are circling. ZEE5 already has a micro drama vertical, Bullet, and Amazon's MX Fatafat is expected to launch soon. Writers are learning to pack each episode with as many twists as possible to keep viewers hooked. Actors are adapting their techniques to the vertical format ("Your lower body and hands are not seen as much in a horizontal screen, but here it's all visible," says Hansraj. "And the biggest thing for actors is, what to do with the hands!"). Saameer Mody of Pocket Films, though, hopes that micro dramas are not monopolised by mainstream talent. "OTT opened the floodgates for a lot of independent filmmakers but once it became popular... independent voices got rounded out," he says.

As cinema-going becomes costlier every day and the convenience of watching TV and movies from home grows, micro dramas may be here to stay. For Pandey, India's industry upstaging even Bollywood in terms of revenue isn't an impossibility. "I don't think it's a question of 'if'," he says assuredly. "It's a question of 'when'." ■

WHERE TO WATCH

Apps to get your micro drama fix

DRAMABOX

One of the first apps to introduce Indians to the world of micro dramas. In just two years, the Chinese company has amassed more than 200 million registered users with its extensive and addictive library of short-form shows.

REELSHORT

One of the top guns in the industry with over 2,000 titles already, its popular offerings sound like titles of *Mills & Boon* novels—*The Double Life of My Billionaire Husband, Married at First Sight, Fated to My Forbidden Alpha* and *The CEO's Contract Wife*.

KUKUTV

KukuFM's KukuTV is one of the earliest Indian entrants in the market. Its bouquet includes shows with 50-plus episodes on average, in Hindi, Telugu, Kannada, and Bengali, and spans genres like action, romance, and mythology.

QUICKTV

Launched in 2025, a subsidiary of the popular app ShareChat, it already has 10 million downloads. It specialises in hyperlocal micro dramas which cater to audiences in Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns. Popular titles include *Ghar Wapsi, Fortune Price* and *Hero No. 1*.

STORYTV

In a two-month span, Eloelo Group's Story TV has released over 200 micro dramas across genres and gained 5 million users in process. Its target is to launch 800+ micro dramas and cross 100 million users in a year. The most-watched shows include *Death Clock* in which the protagonist has the ability to see people's time of death on their forehead.



"I hope mainstream voices don't monopolise micro dramas, like they did OTT when it became popular"

SAAMEER MODY
Founder of Pocket Films